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United Kingdom Liaison Mission in Japan

TOKYO.

SECRET
119/1232/51

FJ 10310/9

27th September, 1951.

FJ 10310/8

Dear Scott,

Your letter of the 21st September about Japanese recognition of Chiang Kai Shek has arrived while Dening is still on the high seas, and though I shall show it to him as soon as he reaches Tokyo, I feel I ought to give you some preliminary comments.

The present attitude of the Japanese Government is given in my despatch No. 316 of the 19th September and I think you will agree that it is satisfactory. The attitude of the Americans here, which I described to Charles Johnston in my letter No. 119/1203/51 of the 20th September, is, at any rate as far as the United States Ambassador is concerned, a little disquieting.

All my information goes to show that, if left to themselves, the present Japanese intention is not to commit themselves to the Nationalists. When I saw Iguchi, the Vice Minister for Foreign Affairs, he himself raised the question of China and said that he wished me to know that the Japanese Government intended to open the projected Overseas Agency in Taipeh earlier than originally proposed - some time in October or November - and that this decision had been prompted solely for trade reasons, namely that a Japanese Trade Fair was shortly to open in Formosa and it was considered desirable to have a Japanese economic agency functioning by that date. Japanese policy towards the Nationalists in Formosa was concentrated solely on the development of trade. Iguchi then went over much the same ground as Yoshida had done in his last conversations with me, of which Iguchi was aware. In delivering my little lecture about the danger to Japan of precipitate action, I did, with your letter at the back of my mind, add a word about the possibility of antagonising certain of the signatories of the Peace Treaty.

At the moment we are on an exceptionally good wicket with the Japanese and the Prime Minister has said to me in practically so many words that the United Kingdom enjoys, with the United States, a unique position and that co-operation with us is a fundamental part of his policy. In practice this now means that any requests or representations we make are treated with the utmost seriousness and promptness that would do credit to any government. (This happy situation may not last for long and/

R. H. Scott, Esq., C.M.G., C.B.E.,

Foreign Office.

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and it has, of course, its dangers, and I think we must be careful not to ask too much nor to use our present advantageous situation to ask for trifles.)

As regards Japanese recognition of the Chinese Nationalists, the Japanese know our views and broadly speaking they share them for reasons of self-interest. At the moment, therefore, it would, I think, be unnecessary and a serious tactical mistake to delay ratification or to threaten to do so as a form of pressure on the Japanese. Their present receptiveness to what we say makes the threat superfluous, and anyhow there is no need to bludgeon as well as preach to the converted. If, however, the Americans start to put pressure on the Japanese to come to some settlement with Chiang Kai Shek or if the Japanese show signs of wobbling, then I think that willy-nilly and most reluctantly they would be forced to acquiesce. In such circumstances, I certainly think that we should consider most seriously the threat of a delay in ratification though it occurs to me that it might be more useful vis-a-vis of the Americans than of the Japanese. I should, therefore, be against any very early ratification. The General Election, however, means a delay in any case and at the same time permits the question to be left over for a few months.

I am sending a copy of this letter to Tomlinson at Washington.

Yours ever

George Clutton

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